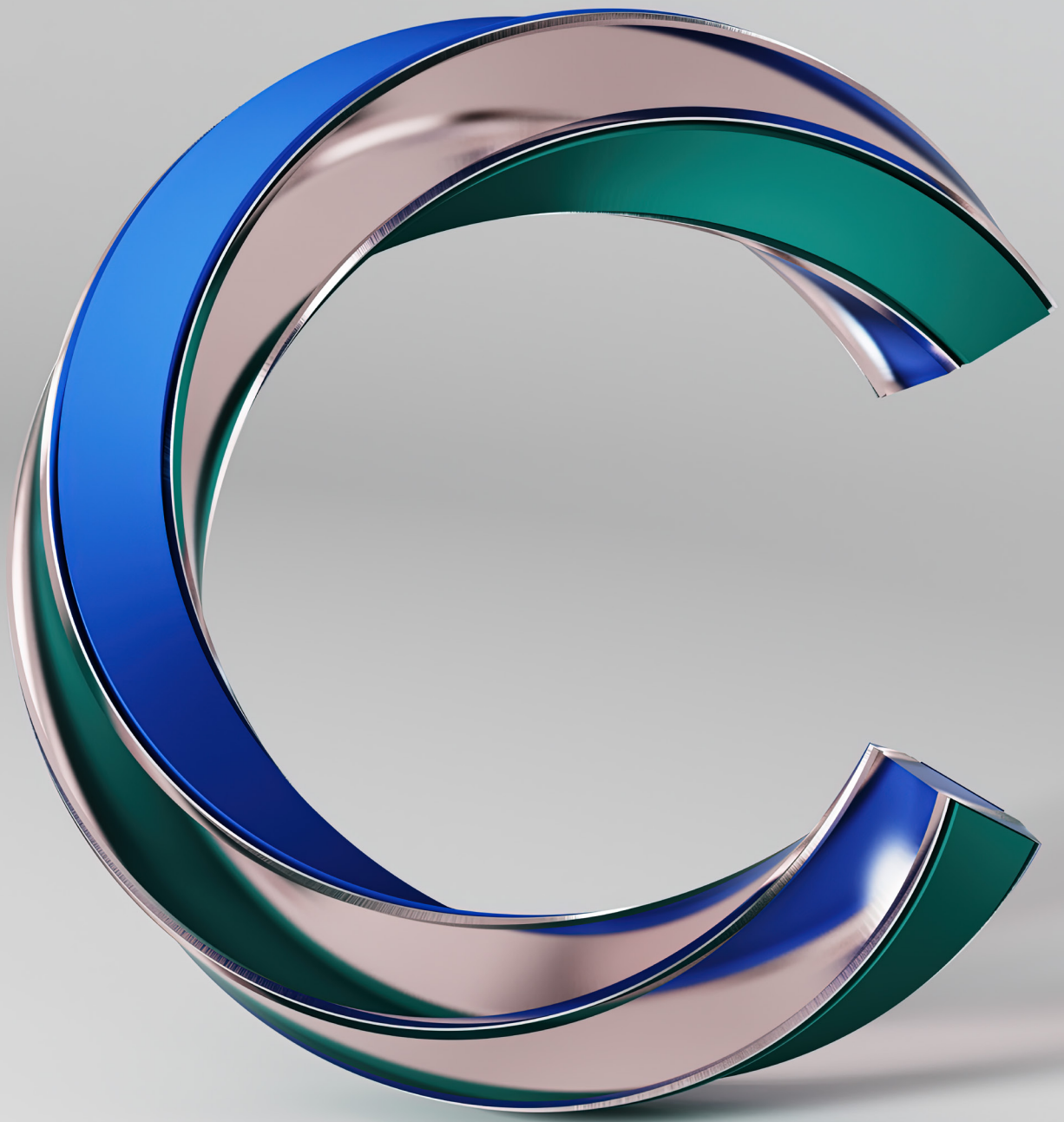
Global C-suite Series
2026 CHRO Study



Designing the Thinking Organization

5 focus areas for CHROs as AI reshapes work

IBM

IBM Institute for Business Value

About the study

For the 2026 CHRO Study, the IBM Institute for Business Value, in cooperation with Oxford Economics, surveyed 1,500 CHROs and senior executives responsible for workforce strategy from 21 geographies and 23 industries between April and June 2026. A second survey, in partnership with SurveyMonkey, was conducted in June 2026 with 8,800 full-time employees to capture their expectations and motivations in an AI-enabled workplace.

In addition to survey responses, insights were drawn from a series of CHRO interviews conducted between April and August 2026. These conversations focused on how CHROs are preparing their organizations to thrive in an AI-enabled future of work, spanning work redesign, the evolving role of HR, human capabilities, culture, performance, governance, employee trust, and what it takes to make human-AI systems work at scale.

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Foreword

Notes from the proving ground



Nickle LaMoreaux
Senior Vice President and CHRO
IBM

AI has already proven its ability to make organizations more productive. The opportunity now is to build on those gains, using the capacity AI creates to drive growth, innovation and new value. Realizing that opportunity requires a fundamental shift: as AI becomes embedded in how organizations operate, human and technology strategies can no longer be designed separately. That puts Chief Human Resources Officers (CHROs) at the center of the redesign. They shape the work, the workforce, and the capabilities that let AI augment human judgment—and turn that judgment into new business value.

At IBM, we've experienced this evolution firsthand through our Client Zero journey, using our HR organization as a proving ground for AI transformation. When we began in 2016, our focus was largely on productivity and efficiency, automating repetitive tasks, simplifying processes and giving employees time back. Those gains allowed us to reinvest in higher-value work rather than simply doing the same work with fewer resources. HR professionals who once spent significant time answering routine questions can now focus on advising managers through complex workforce challenges and helping leaders make better talent decisions. AI didn't just change the process; it allowed us to rethink the role people play within it.

That shift has shaped the next phase of our transformation. We are increasingly focused on how AI can help IBM grow and innovate by enabling people to spend more time applying distinctly human capabilities: judgment, creativity, empathy, relationship building, and complex problem solving. That gives people more time to understand what clients need, identify new opportunities, develop better solutions, and make decisions that move the business forward.

We've also seen the impact on employee experience. Removing friction from everyday work while creating opportunities for people to contribute at a higher level has strengthened engagement, ownership, and a culture of experimentation and continuous learning.

Our experience has reinforced that AI transformation is ultimately business transformation. There is no universal playbook. Every organization must define AI-enabled reinvention in the context of how it creates value, how its culture operates, and what its talent strategy requires. The opportunity for CHROs is to ensure that the capacity AI creates becomes a catalyst not only for efficiency but for business growth and human potential.

Introduction

The Thinking Organization starts here

Three years from now, AI could be doing half the cognitive work in your organization. It is no longer a fantastical premise—it's a reality. It also forces a decision. With all that time freed, do you take the productivity cost savings and declare victory? Or do you grow, innovate, and build something new?

Not enough CHROs are positioned to answer, because they're not in the room when AI decisions are made. Nearly half of organizations—46%—don't involve the CHRO when AI strategy is defined. At best, HR is consulted on workforce implications after the fact.

Enterprises pulling ahead treat AI as growth capital, not a cost-takeout program. Growth runs through employee experience: the confidence, clarity, and support that turn AI's freed capacity into new value. Owning growth does not require a new mandate. It requires fully claiming the one HR already has.

"I don't do HR for HR. I do HR for business."

Anne-Catherine Ropers
Group Head of Human Resources, Crédit Agricole S.A.

A Thinking Organization brings people and AI together to make better decisions, continually adapt how work gets done, and turn new capacity into growth.

Two very different futures for HR are taking shape. In one, HR shrinks to a specialty function, managing the human slice of an automated operation. In the other, HR architects how people and technology work together. Five years from now, CHROs will have either helped build the future of work—or been made irrelevant by it. The difference comes down to the capabilities organizations are building now.

What makes a Thinking Organization?

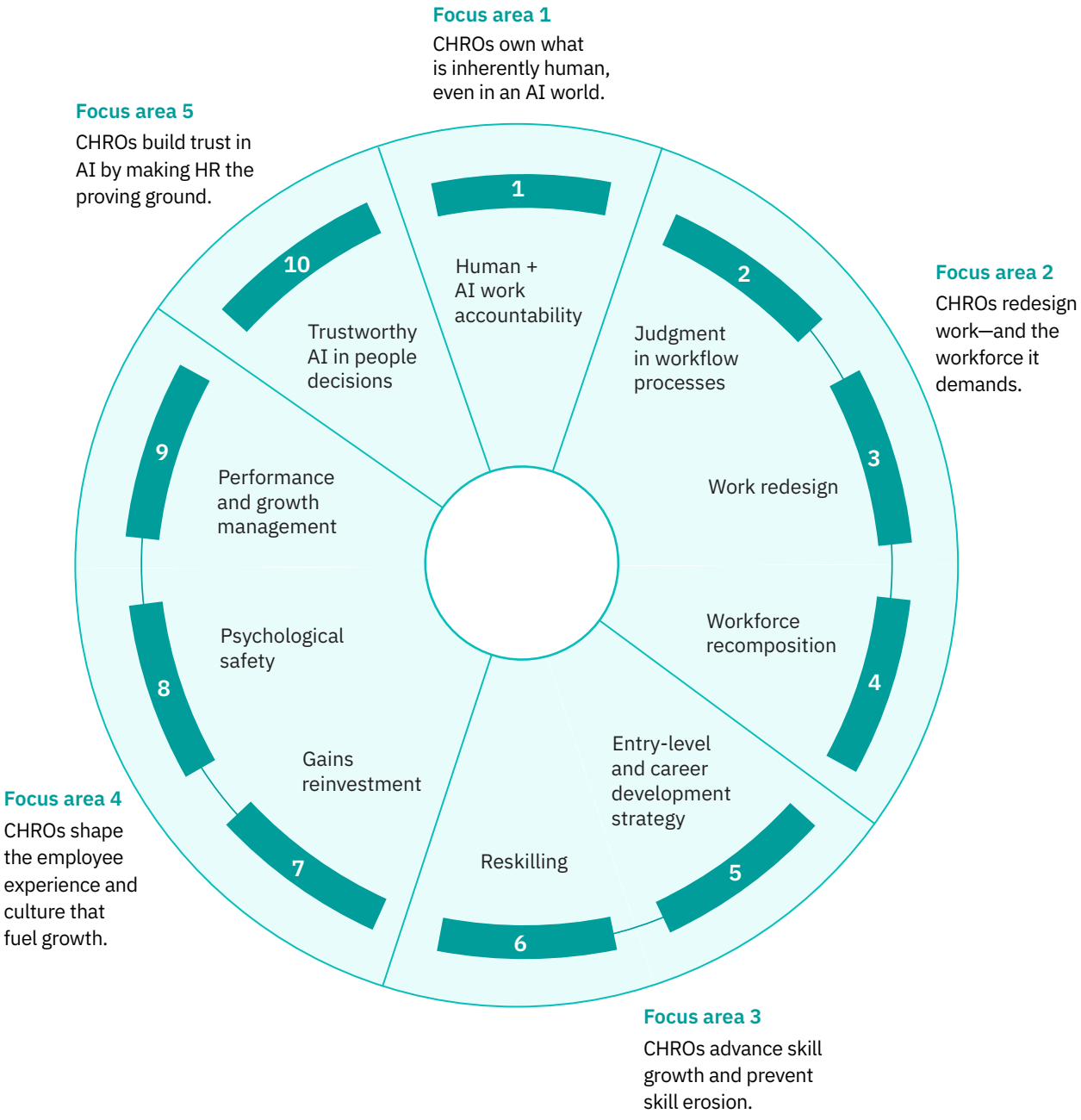
To understand what separates the enterprises converting AI into growth from those merely turning it into savings, the IBM Institute for Business Value surveyed 1,500 CHROs and senior executives with responsibility for workforce strategy along with 8,800 employees worldwide—across two distinct surveys. Through this analysis (see research methodology on page 48), we identified 10 capabilities of the Thinking Organization (see Figure 1 on page 6).

A Thinking Organization is not necessarily the one with the most AI. Our analysis identified 10 capabilities that cluster into five focus areas for action. These focus areas represent decisions CHROs must make to transform AI-created capacity into business growth.

> "For the first time in 80 years, CHROs could be leading instead of enabling or supporting."
>
> **Janine Vos**
> Managing Board Member and CHRO, Rabobank

FIGURE 1

10 capabilities of the Thinking Organization



No organization in our research has excelled in all 10 capabilities of the Thinking Organization—but most leaders are building strength in some, laying the groundwork for growth. The five focus areas in this report are how CHROs begin—or advance—the journey to embracing these 10 capabilities and making their enterprise a Thinking Organization positioned for the future.

The rest of this report covers each focus area in turn: what the data show, what the organizations getting it right do differently, and where to start.

1 CHROs own what is inherently human, even in an AI world.

2 CHROs redesign work—and the workforce it demands.

3 CHROs advance skill growth and prevent skill erosion.

4 CHROs shape the employee experience and culture that fuel business growth.

5 CHROs build trust in AI by making HR the proving ground.



The payoff for becoming a Thinking Organization

Organizations that combine human and AI capabilities are seeing significantly stronger gains in revenue, workforce performance, and innovation than in traditional productivity metrics. The message is clear. Leaders are not using AI simply to do the same work faster or cheaper. They are using it to rethink how work gets done, how people contribute, and ultimately how the organization creates entirely new sources of value.

What do organizations with the strongest Thinking Organization capabilities achieve?



2x revenue uplift

They achieve almost 2x greater revenue uplift than organizations with the weakest capabilities. Rather than focusing solely on productivity gains, they are more successful at translating AI into new sources of business value and growth.



2x stronger workforce outcomes

Their workforce outcomes are nearly 2x stronger. They use AI not only to automate work, but to improve workforce capability, productivity, engagement, and retention better than organizations with the weakest capabilities.

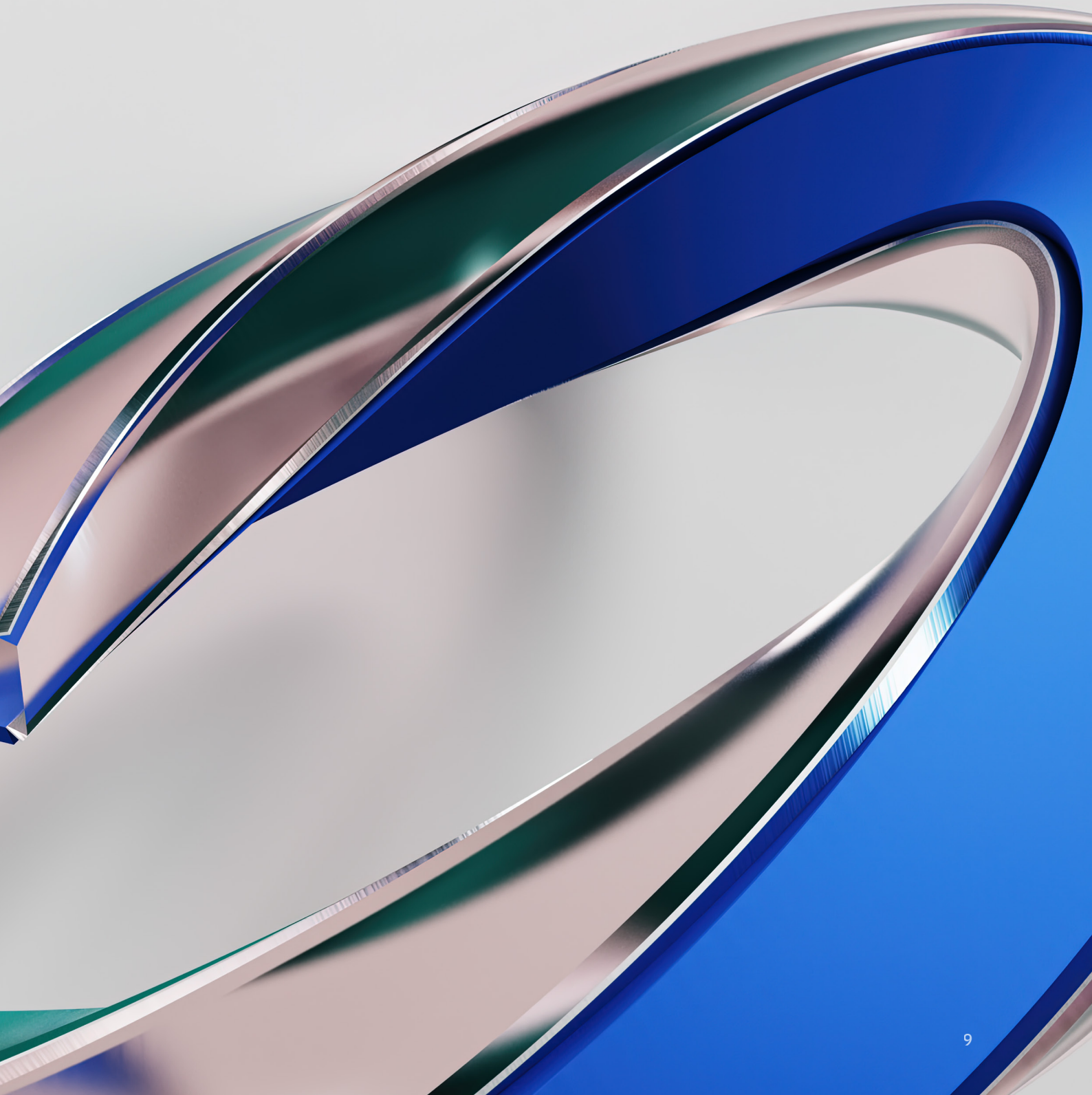


2x higher innovation throughput

Their innovation throughput is nearly 2x higher. They generate, test, scale, and commercialize new ideas, turning AI into a catalyst for innovation better than organizations with the weakest capabilities.

"Technology is technology, and this one may be very, very powerful, but at the end of the day ... AI today is the promise of the internet at the beginning of the '90s."

geneviève bich, Vice President - Human Resources (CHRO), METRO, and Board member





Focus area 1

In an AI world, CHROs own what is inherently human.

Thinking Organization capabilities:

Human + AI work accountability
Define HR's role in shaping, governing, and scaling work where people and AI collaborate.



Today's reality

No single executive is accountable for the full scope of AI transformation. In almost half of organizations, the CHRO isn't in the room when AI strategy is set.

The focus area in action

Employees stop deferring to the machine and start supervising it. Where the CHRO holds shared responsibility for who decides what (the human-AI boundary), 76% of those organizations report their employees feel safe to question or override AI.

The return

The enterprise benefits due to growth from the capabilities competitors cannot rent—judgment, relationships, creativity. The employee confidence that puts those capabilities to work is rising in 63% of organizations where the CHRO has shared responsibility for defining what must remain human-led—versus 19% in others.

Every workflow redesign is an opportunity to determine where people add the most value and answers the question: what should people own, and why?

The capabilities that follow help CHROs claim their role in shaping, governing, and scaling the Thinking Organization.

Right now, no one owns the answer

If the CHRO doesn't take the lead on defining how people put AI to work, the CTO, CFO, or COO will. And in much of the market, they already have.

Enterprise intelligence (how the organization thinks and decides with AI) is scattered across IT, operations, and finance. Each runs its own piece; only 28% of executives report a joint roadmap with IT backed by a shared cadence. In many organizations, no single executive is accountable for deciding and enforcing which decisions must remain human-led. Even where HR is in the conversation, coordination remains weak: 73% of CHROs struggle to align C-suite decisions about how AI will change work and the workforce.

Thinking Organizations, by the numbers:

More than
2x
as likely to give CHROs clear responsibility for defining and enforcing which decisions must remain human-led.

More than
3x
as likely to have strong, ongoing CHRO/C-suite collaboration with shared accountability for AI outcomes.

Nearly
2x
as likely to integrate AI agents into workforce planning through HR-led or shared HR-IT governance, compared to only 23% of all others.

An unclaimed mandate this large doesn't stay unclaimed. The C-suite can already see where it's headed: 77% of CEOs say talent and technology leadership roles are converging.[1] Enterprises can no longer design human and technological capability separately. Every deployment now decides what AI will do, and the people capabilities that are essential. Protecting what is inherently human means owning the human-capability agenda in every room where AI's role is being decided.

Where CHROs own the human-AI boundary, behavior changes

When the CHRO takes responsibility for defining which decisions remain human-led, something changes on the front line: employees stop deferring to the machine and start supervising it. The pattern is measurable across the full spectrum of CHRO responsibility—from no role, to advisory, to shared, to primary, to enterprise-wide—and it moves in one direction: the deeper the ownership, the better the outcomes.

Employees feel safe to question or override an AI recommendation in 76% of organizations where the CHRO shares that responsibility—versus 43% where HR is merely advisory. That safety is employee experience in its most concrete form—and it is not a soft benefit. As Niharika Mohan Vohra, CHRO of Schneider Electric's Greater India Zone, explains: "We don't view AI as a source of absolute truth. In our organization, AI is a co-pilot, not an autopilot. It is a powerful tool that enhances judgment, but it does not replace it. The best decisions will continue to come from a combination of data-driven insights and human wisdom." When employees see that AI is treated as an input rather than an unquestionable authority, they are more likely to trust and engage with it. CHRO ownership of the human-AI boundary is what converts a workforce that is merely willing to use technology into one that engages critically with the tools.

> "We think of the CHRO and CTO as the power couple because they are bringing talent strategy and technology strategy into one conversation. Together, we're co-architects of the work."

Ali Peek Bebo
CHRO, Pearson

Employee confidence is where growth starts

Every organization has access to the same AI models. What they cannot rent is critical thinking, judgment, client relationships, and the creative work the technology cannot replicate. Growth accrues to the organizations that decide, deliberately, which human capabilities offer competitive advantage and then protect them in the design of work. "We know that a high percentage of AI pilots fail to deliver measurable business impact, which tells me that access to tools isn't enough," explains Ana White, EVP and Chief People & AI Enablement Officer for Lumen Technologies. "Pour your energy into your people more than tools."

Capabilities pay off through use, and use takes confidence. Employee confidence in AI-enabled decisions is rising in 63% of organizations where the CHRO shares the ownership of what remains human-led, versus 19% where they do not. A gap that wide isn't about the technology. It's the measurable difference strong CHRO ownership makes.

Deciding what remains inherently human is deciding how the enterprise will compete. The CHRO who owns that answer becomes an integral part of the entire organization's AI strategy.

> "Value judgments, risk assessments, and ethical decisions are fundamentally human responsibilities, which makes meaningful human involvement, shaped by diverse perspectives and experiences, essential."

Yasuhito Ohwaki
CHRO, Nitto Denko Corporation

CHRO priorities for a Thinking Organization

Build the business and technology fluency necessary to influence AI decisions.

Understand how AI tools are selected, deployed, measured, and governed well enough to ask better questions. What decisions will this system shape? What data is it using? Where could bias, error, or overreliance emerge? What human capability does it strengthen or weaken? Use those answers to challenge assumptions and connect AI choices to business performance, risk, and employee trust.

Design and govern how decision rights and accountability change as AI becomes part of work.

The business owns the workflow and the outcome; the CHRO architects the human-AI system around it—the capabilities, judgment, roles, and workforce it requires. Start with an inventory: where is AI already shaping employee and manager decisions, and which three to five workflows carry the highest stakes for human judgment? That inventory grounds the design—made explicit and shared with IT, operations, finance, and business leaders—so AI transformation is guided by clear human and organizational principles, not treated only as a technology rollout.

Negotiate shared accountability with C-suite peers for AI outcomes.

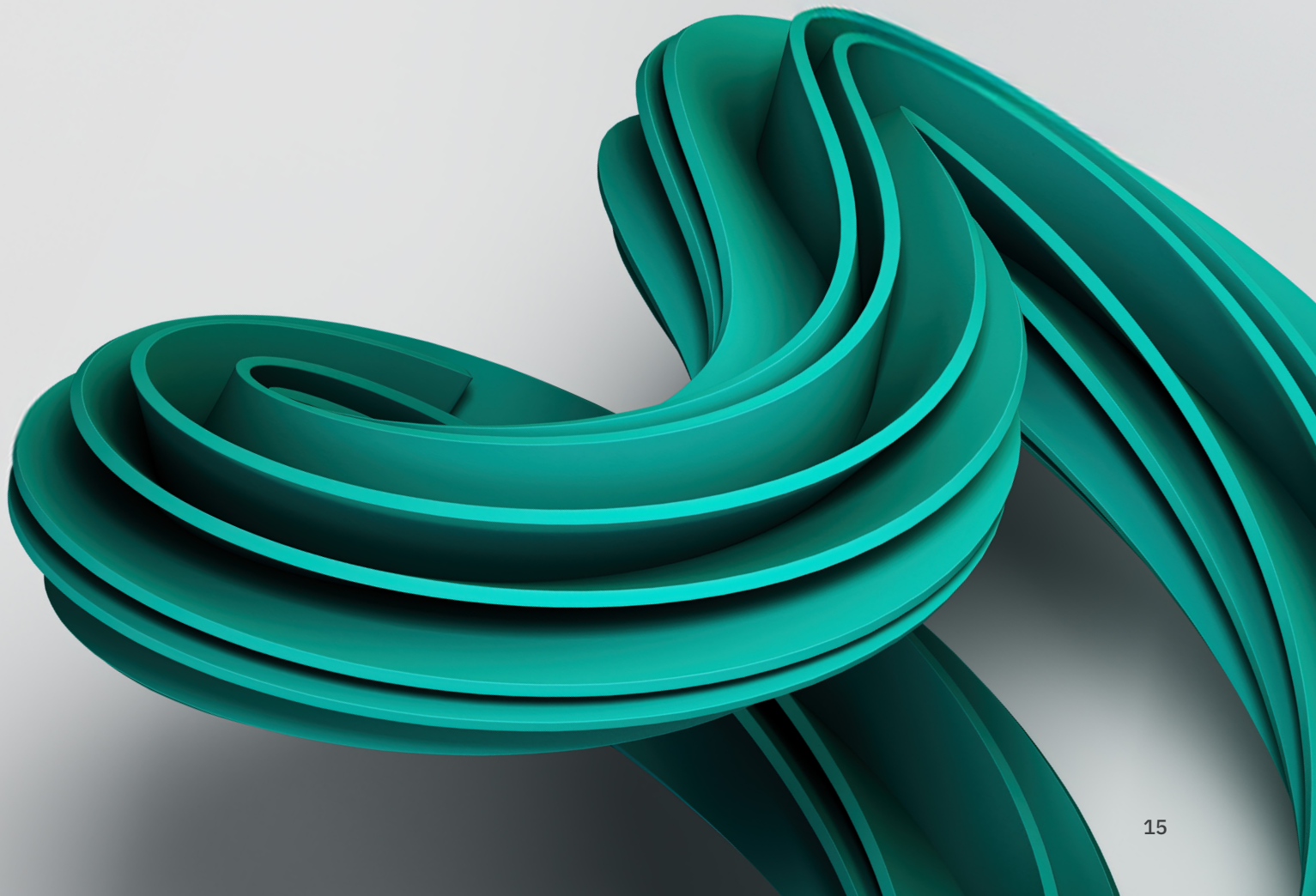
Sit down with technology, operations, and finance leaders and clarify how each function contributes to shared outcomes—workforce, productivity, risk—then keep meeting on it as deployments evolve. Make it concrete: every major deployment has a named owner for its workforce impact, and when an AI-driven decision goes wrong, the review happens jointly instead of each function inspecting its own piece.

"AI is about enterprise transformation. It's about future of work. It's about competencies. It's about leadership. It's much more about all of this than about technology."

geneviève bich
Vice President - Human Resources (CHRO), METRO, and Board member

"An AI-enabled culture that is grounded in the principle that humans are any company's secret sauce will differentiate you versus competitors. AI is a *tool* for humans to perform their best work."

Cecilia McKenney, Senior Vice President & CHRO, Quest Diagnostics





Focus area 2

CHROs redesign work—and the workforce it demands.

Thinking Organization capabilities:

Judgment in workflow processes
Clarify where human judgment, oversight, and escalation are needed as AI becomes part of daily work.

Work redesign
Reconfigure roles, tasks, workflows, and operating models to improve productivity, experience, and business outcomes.

Workforce recomposition
Rebalance roles, skills, capacity, and talent models as work shifts across people, AI, and automation.



Today's reality

Work is changing faster than organizations can manage. Only 26% of organizations clearly define work as human-led, AI-assisted, and/or AI-executed. Only one-quarter manage workforce recomposition as a continuous discipline.

The focus area in action

Every workflow gets an owner, an escalation path, and a workforce shaped to it. Accountability is built in by design, not improvised.

The return

18% risk reduction and 20% quality improvement from clearly defined workflows. Revenue uplift of 4% where recomposition is managed dynamically versus 2% where it is not.

Deciding what stays human is the first act of design. The second is redesigning the enterprise around that decision. AI now performs more of the cognitive work embedded across jobs: analyzing, drafting, recommending, and deciding. And the enterprise is being rebuilt around it: 29% of workflows already incorporate AI agents, headed for 40% by 2028.

The capabilities that follow allow a Thinking Organization to redesign how intelligence, decisions, and talent flow through work.

Design work around decisions, not roles

Where redesign happens, the enterprise stops treating the workforce as a set of fixed roles and starts treating work as a portfolio of decisions, workflows, and responsibilities. Every workflow is defined across human-led, AI-assisted, and AI-executed work. Decision rights and escalation authority are embedded into the flow itself—and genuine career mobility opens in the process.

Thinking Organizations, by the numbers:

84%

have clearly defined responsibilities across human-led, AI-assisted, and AI-executed work.

85%

have mapped high-impact workflows where AI agents materially shape or execute work end-to-end, compared with only 65% of other organizations.

80%

monitor outcomes and establish clear mechanisms to challenge, pause, or override AI-enabled decisions compared to 65% of all others.

That is the pivot in the CHRO's job. It is no longer deciding where people sit; it is designing how intelligence moves. "We're not looking at jobs. We're looking at process, activity and task," explains Anne-Catherine Ropers, Group Head of Human Resources, Crédit Agricole S.A. HR becomes the architect of work recomposition—aligning talent to changing workflows as work evolves. And this design discipline pays: organizations that clearly define workflows as human-led, AI-assisted, or AI-executed achieve 18% risk reduction and 20% quality improvement.

Move accountability from the org chart into the workflow

AI is disrupting the traditional chain of accountability. Fixed roles once made decision ownership relatively clear. As AI distributes work across people and systems, 36% of executives say unclear accountability complicates deployment. Employees feel it most: 43% report that when AI goes wrong, the blame lands on them. Work redesign must make ownership, validation, exception handling, escalation, and override explicit within the workflow.

That design difference changes how employees experience AI. Where judgment is built into work, 62% of CHROs report rising employee confidence in AI-enabled decisions; where it is not, 57% report confidence declining. Same workforce, different work design, opposite outcomes. “Reimagining the work that we do today, and the work we can’t do today but can do tomorrow, will become increasingly important,” says Lynn McManus, chief people officer for Nationwide Building Society.

Work redesign requires work recomposition

Redesigned work staffed by an unchanged workforce is only half a transformation. The redesign should extend to the workforce itself—recomposing roles, teams, and the structure of work so the organization can execute the new workflow consistently at scale. The landscape CHROs are navigating while doing this is complex. Labor dynamics and governing bodies vary by geography. CHROs are increasingly having to inform, consult, and negotiate with those bodies.

Organizations that manage recomposition as a continuous discipline—rather than a one-off exercise—report revenue uplift of 4% versus 2%. Only a quarter of enterprises practice it.

> “Fluency without judgment simply helps an organization make mistakes faster.”
>
> **Dr. Amit Das**
> Director and CHRO, Bennett Coleman & Co. Ltd. (The Times of India)

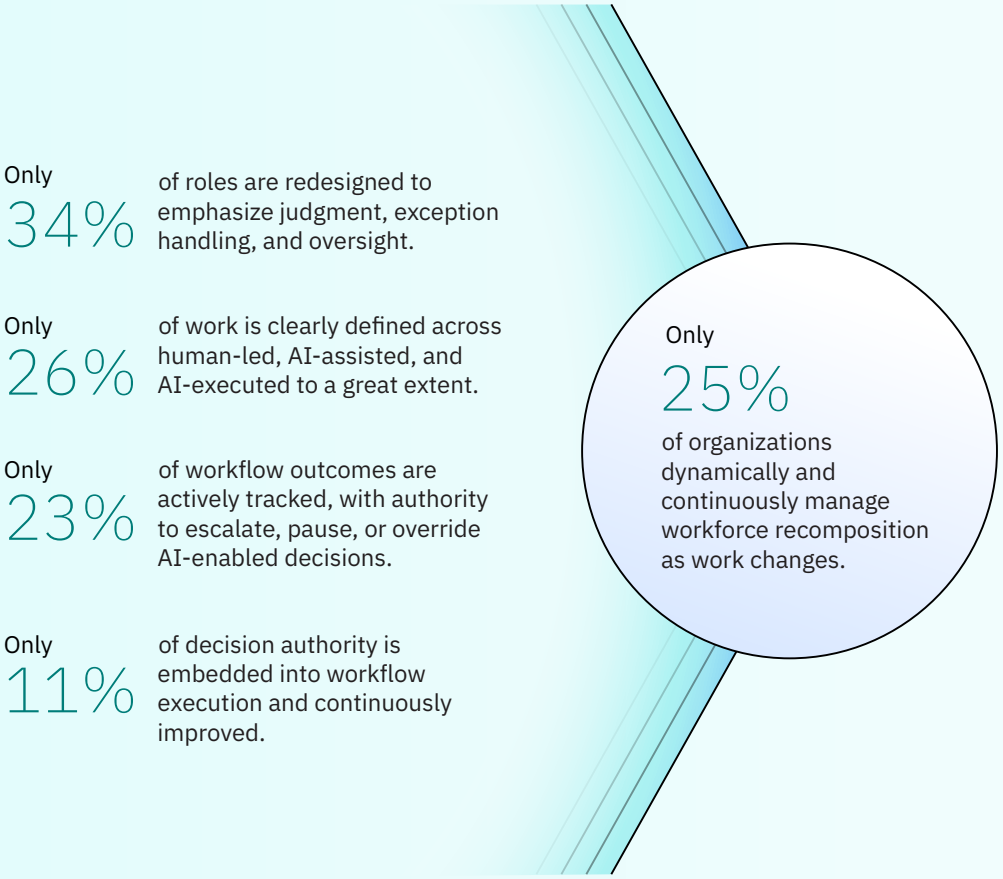
Perspective

Fast workflows, broken work

Work is changing faster than organizations are redesigning it. More than half—52%—of employees say the tasks they are assigned have changed over the past year as AI reshapes day-to-day responsibilities. Yet organizations deliberately designing work remain in the minority. In many organizations, work is evolving through day-to-day adaptation rather than intentional decisions about how people and AI should work together. Thinking Organizations close that gap by treating work redesign and workforce recomposition as continuous disciplines.

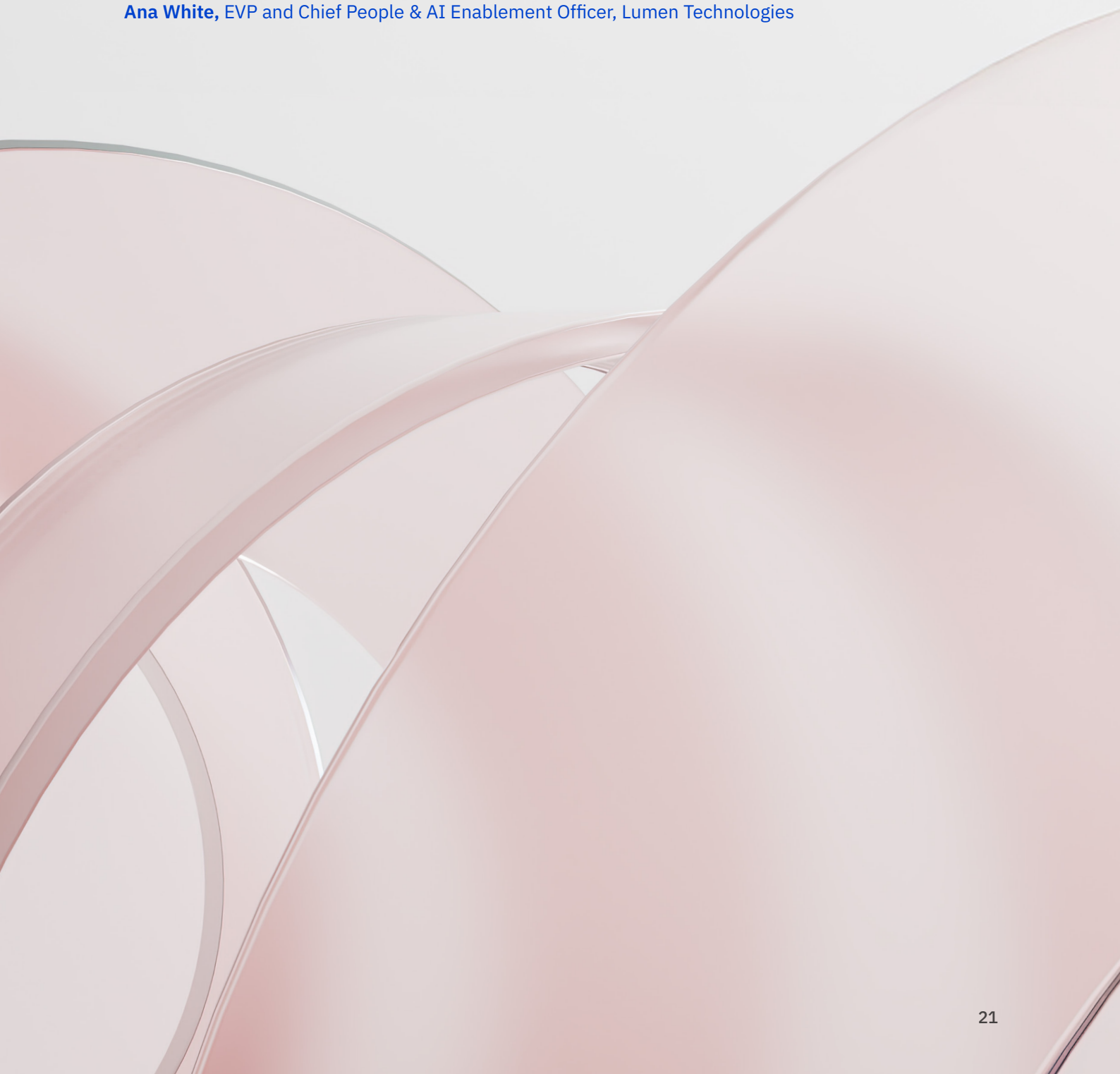
FIGURE 2

Work is changing faster than organizations can redesign and recompose it.



"Moving forward, I believe we'll see CHROs playing a more active role in workforce design and AI transformation across the enterprise. Because of their acumen in building trust and developing talent, I see more CHROs spearheading AI transformation work."

Ana White, EVP and Chief People & AI Enablement Officer, Lumen Technologies



CHRO priorities for a Thinking Organization

Make the decision layer explicit in AI-enabled work.

Select two or three high-impact workflows where AI recommends, decides, or executes work. Define the decision layer for each: where human validation, exception handling, escalation, or override is required; who makes the final decision; and who is accountable for the outcome. Embed timely guidance so employees, managers, and other decision-makers know when and how to intervene. Review incidents and overrides monthly, then adjust the workflow when decision rights or judgment are unclear.

Make work redesign a standing business discipline.

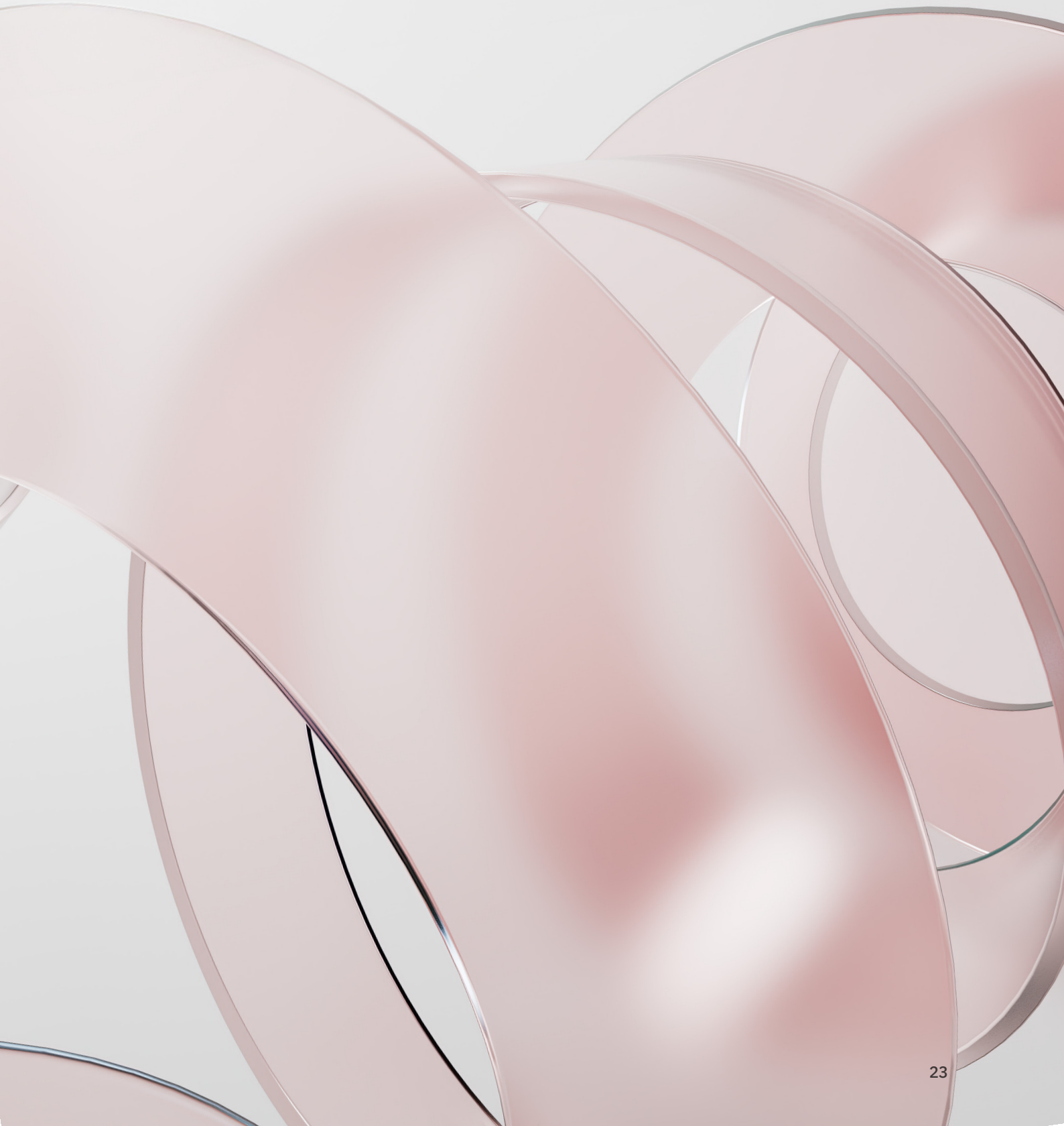
Collaborate with your C-suite colleagues to review how AI is changing tasks, responsibilities, collaboration, employee effort, and customer value. Use a regular operating cadence to redesign these elements together—including decision rights, team structures, performance measures, and the broader operating model. Track quality, speed, employee experience, and business results. Then, revisit the design as AI capabilities and business needs change.

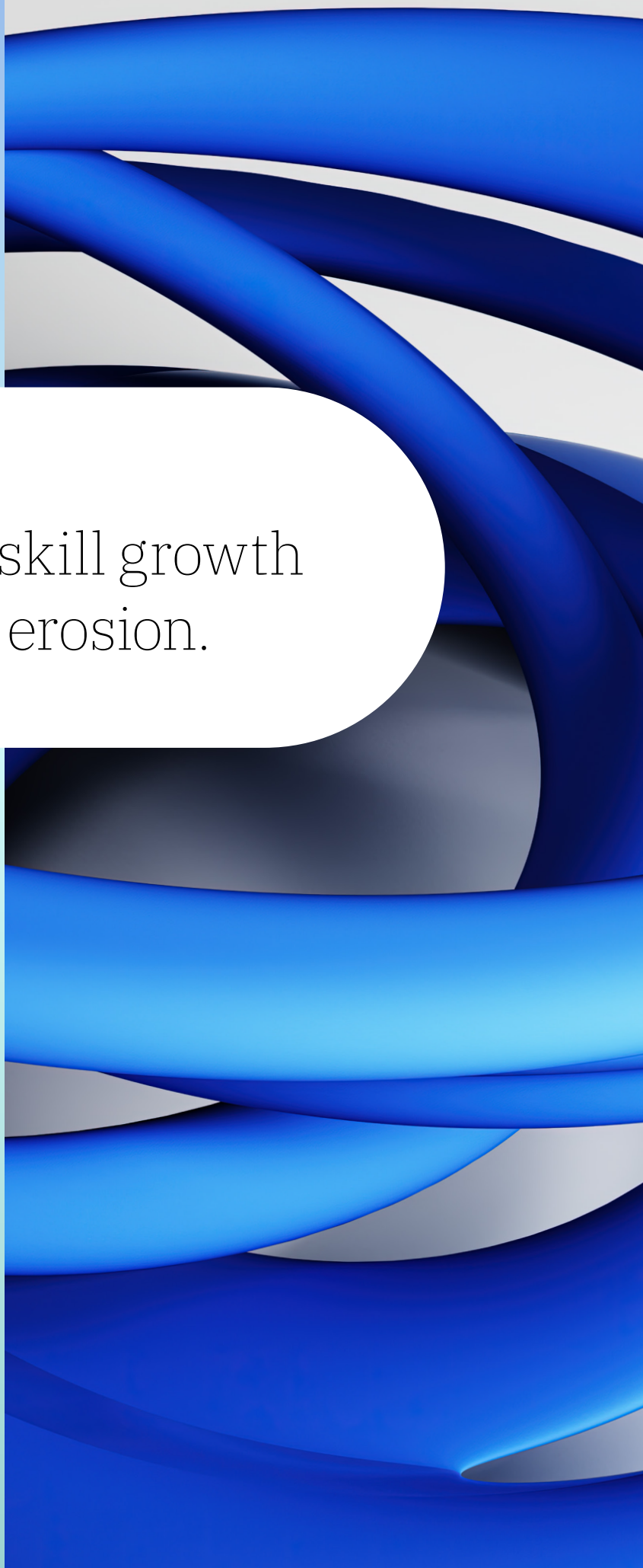
Translate the new work design into workforce planning.

Project demand for capacity and talent models. Identify work that is growing, declining, or shifting to AI, then determine where internal mobility, project assignments, redeployment, or targeted hiring are needed. Work with the leaders of the affected functions or business units to agree which changes to make, who owns each action, and when it will happen.

"We're redesigning the organization around work and task, as opposed to around structure."

Helen Cook
Chief People Officer, Finastra





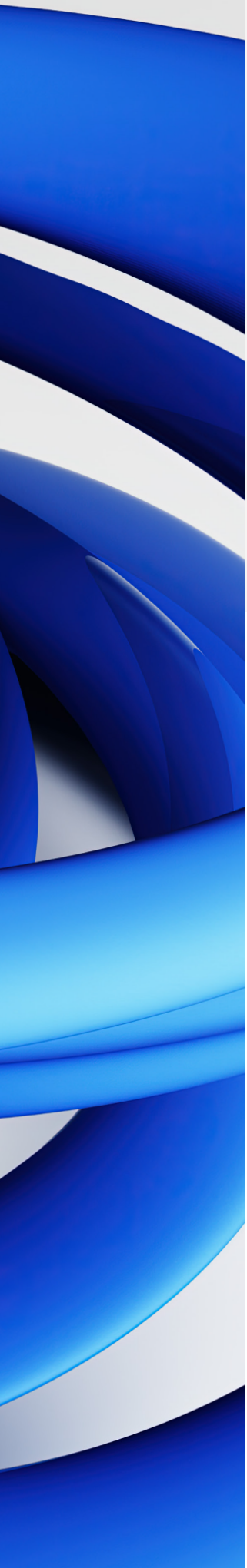
Focus area 3

CHROs advance skill growth and prevent skill erosion.

Thinking Organization capabilities:

Entry-level and career development strategy
Bring entry-level talent into the organization and help them build the skills, experience, and confidence to grow with the business.

Reskilling
Anticipate where skills are shifting and help employees develop the capabilities needed for new ways of working.



Today's reality

Roadmaps often include funding for skill gaps but skill erosion goes unmanaged. Skill erosion is a top concern for 46% of executives and is reported by 60% of employees.

The focus area in action

Organizations identify the skills AI may weaken and create opportunities to practice and develop them. Learning, early-career development, and talent strategies evolve as quickly as work.

The return

A workforce that knows how to make AI better. Thinking Organizations are more likely to report that employees can work effectively with autonomous AI, turning AI output into stronger decisions, better problem solving, and higher-value work.

Enterprises are not ignoring the skills problem: 80% have a reskilling roadmap for their workforce to collaborate with technology. But a roadmap addresses skill gaps—the skills people need to use new AI tools. It does nothing about skill erosion: the skills people already have, that are quietly degrading as AI takes on more of the thinking. A skill gap gets funded. Skill erosion goes unmanaged.

The capabilities that follow help ensure a Thinking Organization develops future capability as quickly as work changes.

The risk of cognitive atrophy

Call it cognitive atrophy: as reliance on AI deepens, the thinking skills people do not exercise begin to fade. Skill erosion now ranks among executives' top concerns and three out of four concerned employees say AI has already begun to erode at least some of their skills. The skill they most often name as declining is critical thinking—the very capability 57% of executives call essential for success.

Thinking Organizations, by the numbers:

91%

report that employees have the skills needed to effectively collaborate with autonomous AI-powered technologies—turning AI adoption into workforce capability.

95%

are confident that recruiting and retention efforts deliver the skills needed to achieve business objectives.

88%

report that managers are prepared to lead teams alongside AI agents. Only 58% of other organizations report the same.

AI is changing how expertise is built

Executives and employees agree on much of the foundation AI-enabled work requires. Both place critical thinking and problem framing near the top, at 57% and 49%, respectively. More concerning is that both groups place creativity near the bottom—even though it is essential to turning generic AI output into something distinctive.

The sharpest divide between executives and employees concerns the skills required to evaluate AI outputs. Seventy-one percent of executives prioritize the ability to supervise, validate, or override AI outputs, compared with 38% of employees.

Employees recognize they must adapt to AI but may be underestimating the evaluative skills organizations expect them to bring to it. That disconnect puts essential evaluation skills at risk: experienced employees may exercise them less, while newer employees may never fully develop them.

"The real risk is the quiet erosion of the experiences through which people learn to think."

Dr. Amit Das
Director and CHRO, Bennett Coleman & Co. Ltd. (The Times of India)

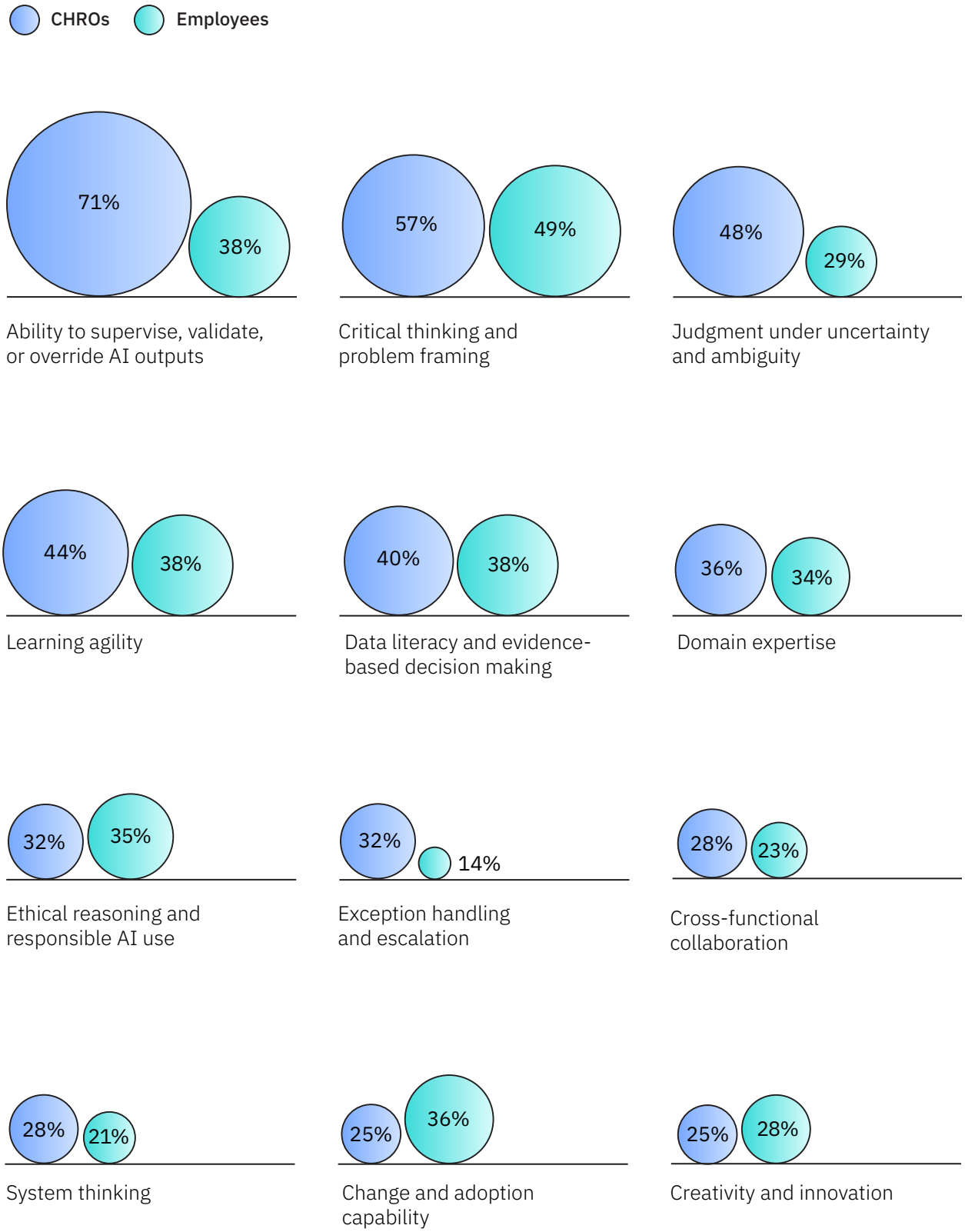
"I used to succession plan for people, then roles, then skills. Today, I need to succession plan for capabilities that don't yet exist and roles we can't yet imagine."

Line De Decker
Chief People Officer, Haleon



FIGURE 3

What skills matter in the AI era? CHROs and employees answer differently.



Perspective

Closing the pathway to experiential learning for less experienced employees?

Only 23% of organizations are increasing entry-level hiring; the rest—77%—are holding flat or pulling back. And when asked which talent segment they are intentionally strengthening to sustain future capability, executives name experienced individual contributors (34%) and first-line managers (27%). Early-career talent? Just 7%. The enterprise is investing in people with deep experience while quietly closing the road by which expertise has traditionally been built. If entry-level work disappears before new pathways are built, organizations may protect today's productivity while weakening tomorrow's leadership bench.

And the bench isn't the only thing at stake. Organizations need another route to expertise. Rotations, supervised decision-making, coaching, and earlier customer exposure can provide the repetitions routine work once supplied. These paths let early-career talent create value now while building the experience the organization will depend on later.

> "I look for lifelong learning, somebody who has an appetite to want to keep piling onto their skills. Someone who is innately curious about what's happening in the world and wondering how that can change their work."
>
> **Caroline Barth,** CHRO, Syngenta Group

CHRO priorities for a Thinking Organization

Use AI to shorten the path from current skills to future work.

Use AI to build a dynamic view of the capabilities employees already have and the work emerging across the business. Identify skill adjacencies, pinpoint the gaps employees need to close, and recommend personalized learning and practice. Connect those recommendations to simulations, projects, coaching, and internal opportunities where employees can apply the new skills. Track verified proficiency and how quickly those capabilities translate into productive work.

Manage skill erosion as a talent risk.

Identify the roles where AI is taking over analysis, problem framing, customer interaction, or other work that builds expertise the organization needs to preserve. Build continued use into development plans, manager coaching, rotations, stretch assignments, and succession planning. Track whether proficiency is holding as AI adoption grows and intervene early when it begins to decline.

Preserve critical early-career learning pathways.

Prioritize a set of entry-level roles that are important to the future talent pipeline and where AI is reducing the work through which employees build judgment and experience. Identify the most important learning opportunities at risk, then preserve them through targeted customer exposure, case reviews, supervised exception handling, rotations, or decision simulations. Assign experienced coaches and define two or three observable milestones that show when employees are ready for more complex assignments and career progression.



"The organizations obsessing over AI productivity gains are, in many cases, quietly hollowing out the developmental infrastructure that produced their own current leaders."

Dr. Amit Das
Director and CHRO, Bennett Coleman & Co. Ltd. (The Times of India)



Focus area 4

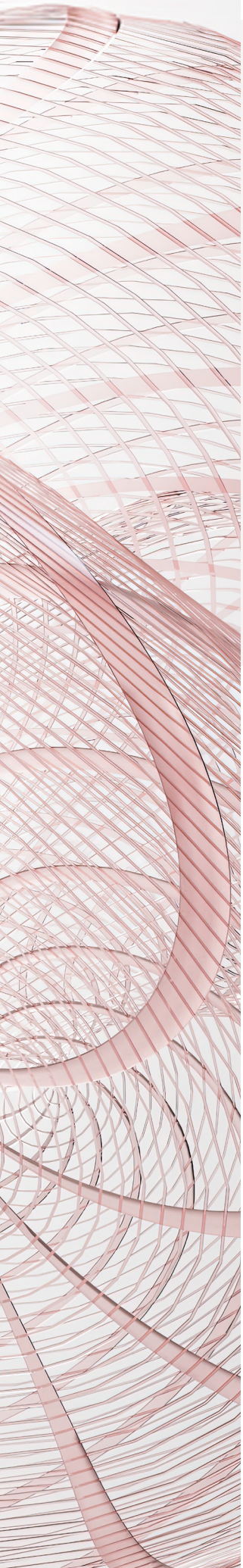
CHROs shape the employee experience and culture that fuel business growth.

Thinking Organization capabilities:

Performance and growth management
Evolve how performance, development, and contribution are defined and measured in human + AI work.

Psychological safety
Build the trust and openness employees need to question, test, learn, and adapt through change.

Gains reinvestment
Channel time, cost, and productivity gains into skills, innovation, employee experience, and higher-value work.



Today's reality

Employees are more ready for AI than executives assume, but culture shapes their experience as it becomes part of daily work. Where culture is strong, 62% of CHROs report rising employee confidence in AI-related decisions; where it is weak, only 13% do.

The focus area in action

AI-freed capacity becomes a source of growth rather than a one-time efficiency gain. CHROs shape the culture and employee experience around AI by updating how contribution is recognized and rewarded, reinvesting gains in employee growth and opportunity. They also hold leaders accountable for creating an environment where people can speak up.

The return

Up to 73% higher revenue growth and an 11% operating-margin gain for organizations pairing advanced AI adoption with strong change capability.[2] Extracted capacity buys margin once; reinvested capacity compounds.

AI deployments often end with the same question: where do the gains go? The answer is a cultural decision before it is a financial one—and it shapes employee experience. Culture shows up in what the organization recognizes and rewards, how AI-freed capacity is used, and whether employees feel safe challenging AI.

The capabilities that follow detail how Thinking Organizations build the cultural capabilities that turn AI-created capacity into growth.

AI-funded productivity does not equate to workforce strength

Most organizations have not made reinvestment the default. Only 42% primarily direct AI productivity gains to innovation or reskilling. The rest either split them between savings and reinvestment, take them as cost reduction or profit, or lack a clear path from productivity to opportunity.

AI-funded productivity is not the same as workforce strength. An enterprise can post impressive efficiency numbers while the workforce within it weakens. The difference comes down to what happens to the gains.

The cost of extraction is already visible. Forty-nine percent of executives say losing employee trust is their greatest concern as AI reshapes the workforce.

Thinking Organizations, by the numbers:

More than
2x
more likely than others (87% vs. 38%) to empower HR to shape the cultural norms that drive AI adoption.

More than
1.5x
as likely than others (83% vs. 53%) to use employee feedback to determine whether AI solutions are scaled.

Nearly
1.5x
more likely than others (88% vs. 59%) to establish clear norms and expectations for operating as an AI-first enterprise.

Use performance management to reinforce culture

Performance management is one of culture's clearest signals: what gets recognized and rewarded tells employees what the organization values. AI is changing what employee contribution looks like. Eighty percent of executives say adoption creates unrecognized work—validating recommendations, correcting errors, adding context, and managing exceptions. Forty-two percent of employees say AI either increases their work or leaves that work unrecognized. Traditional performance measures will miss much of this contribution if they continue to index on output volume.

Performance management must recognize quality and outcomes in AI-related work. It should also credit people with the work required to ensure reliable output. When this type of new work becomes visible in goals, feedback, and reviews, employees then see it matters.

"If the reinvestment is you've saved 10 minutes per person per day and it goes into doing one more email, that's not a good use of anyone's time."

geneviève bich
Vice President - Human Resources (CHRO), METRO, and Board member

Build a culture that reinvests in employee growth

When AI frees employee time, organizations must decide how that capacity will be used. Without an explicit plan, it is likely to be absorbed by additional work or captured as cost savings. CHROs can instead direct it toward coaching, development, internal mobility, stretch assignments, and innovation. That choice sends its own cultural signal, showing employees whether AI-created capacity will expand their opportunities to learn, contribute, and grow.

This is where employee growth and business growth reinforce each other. Organizations pairing advanced AI adoption with strong change capability report up to 73% higher revenue growth and an 11% operating-margin gain compared to peers.[3] Employees gain opportunities to develop and contribute in new ways, while the organization builds the capabilities and adaptability needed for future performance.

"Technology can make us faster and more efficient, but empathy remains uniquely human. The ability to listen, understand context, and build genuine connections will become even more valuable in an AI-driven world."

Niharika Mohan Vohra, CHRO, Greater India Zone, Schneider Electric

"As the enterprise HR function, our role is to prioritize the colleague experience—to make sure this shift to new technology feels empowering, not overwhelming."

Kristin Oliver, CHRO, Hyatt Hotels Corporation

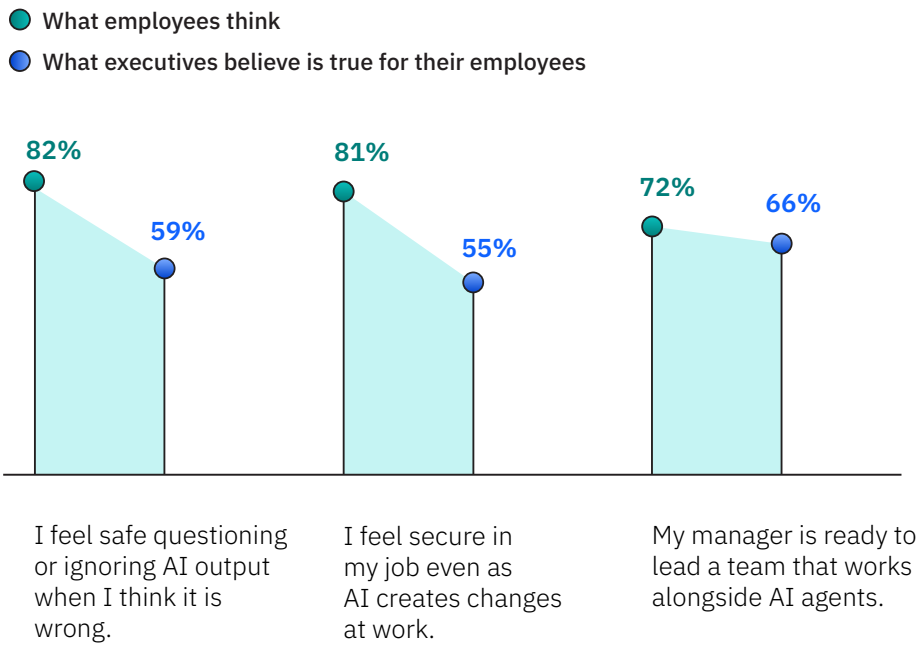
Create a culture where employees can speak up

Where culture is strong, 62% of CHROs report rising employee confidence in AI, compared with just 13% where culture is weak.

Formal escalation paths establish what employees are allowed to do. Culture determines whether they feel safe doing it. Psychological safety grows when managers invite concerns, respond without blame, and demonstrate that employee feedback matters. Employees feel safe questioning or overriding AI recommendations in 76% of organizations where CHROs have shared responsibility for determining which decisions remain human. That drops to 43% when HR's role is merely advisory. This is employee experience in one of its most tangible forms.

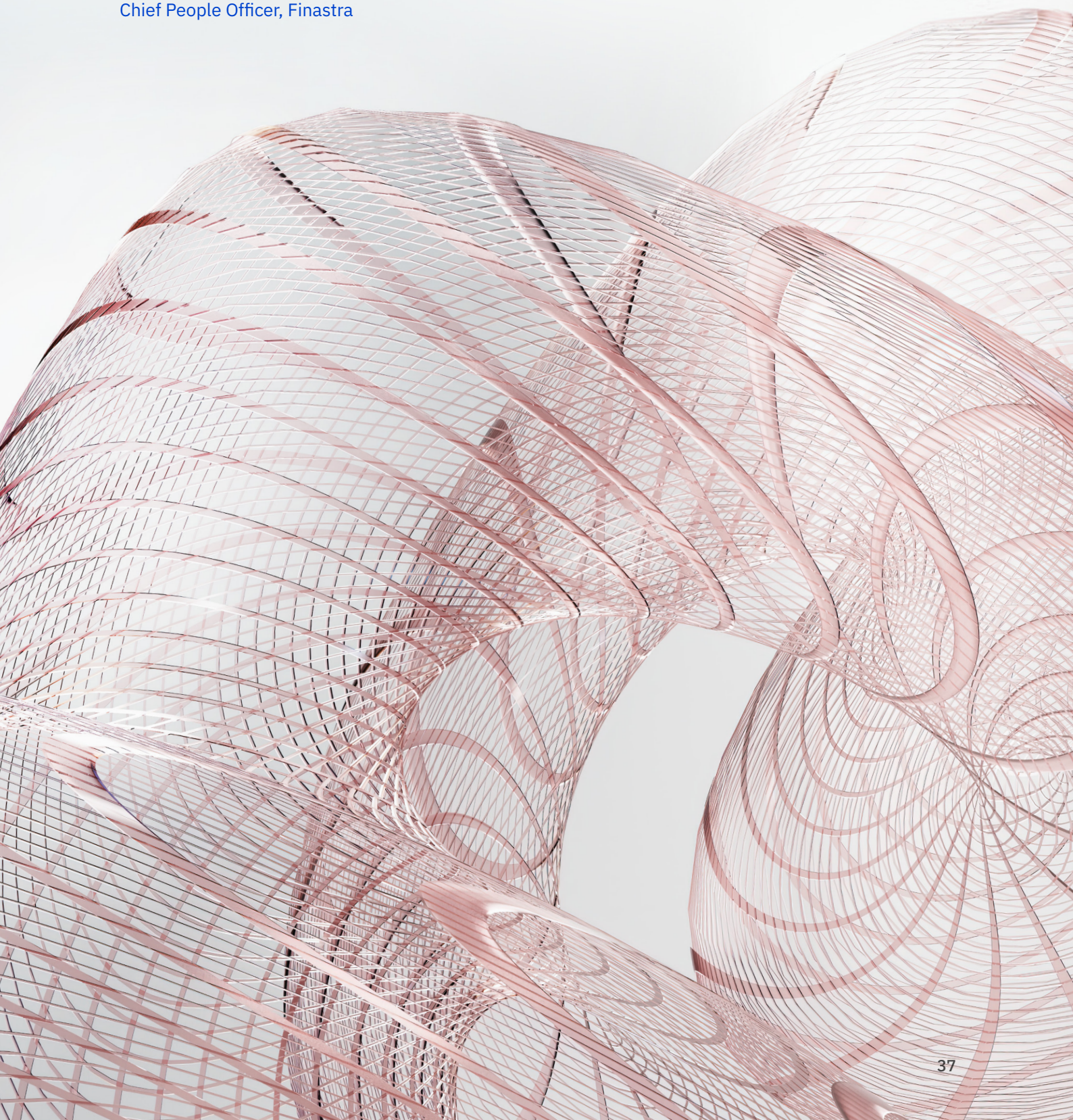
FIGURE 4

Executives expect anxiety.
Employees report optimism.



"It's really important to make sure it's just not a technology topic. It's so much bigger. It is a fundamental cultural revolution of how work is done."

Helen Cook
Chief People Officer, Finastra



CHRO priorities for a Thinking Organization

Normalize constructive challenge through everyday management.

One way employees experience organizational culture is the manner in which managers respond when they question an AI recommendation. Set a few clear expectations for AI-enabled work: question weak recommendations, report errors, share lessons, and ask for help when new skills are needed. Require managers to model these behaviors, invite concerns, respond without blame, and explain what changed as a result of employee feedback. Use regular employee feedback and issue-resolution data to identify teams where people do not feel safe or supported to challenge AI, experiment, or ask for development support—and coach leaders accordingly.

Rewrite performance goals for human + AI contribution.

As AI changes how results are achieved, performance goals show employees what the culture values. Pilot revised goals in one function. Define the outcome, the employee's contribution, the role of AI, and the evidence managers will use to assess performance. Limit each set of goals to three to five measures focused on business or customer results, collaboration, and employee growth. Align managers before the performance cycle begins and again when results are assessed. Then refine the approach before scaling it.

Shape how AI-created capacity supports workforce priorities and employee experience.

Establish a gains-reinvestment approach for select AI deployments expected to release significant capacity or reshape employee work. Partner with business, finance, and technology leaders to estimate the potential gains and decide how they can support skill building, innovation, employee opportunity, and other growth priorities. The business or functional leader accountable for the deployment should own the reinvestment plan. After implementation, compare expected and actual gains. Redirect unused capacity before it is absorbed into added workload or budget savings. Show employees where the gains went and what new opportunities they created.

"Rather than asking how much work was completed, we're asking whether AI helped improve decision quality, speed, employee experience, guest satisfaction, and business performance."

Kristin Oliver
CHRO, Hyatt Hotels Corporation





Focus area 5

CHROs build trust in AI by making HR the proving ground.

Thinking Organization capabilities:

Trustworthy AI in people decisions
Establish transparency, guardrails, and accountability so AI is used responsibly in workforce and people decisions.





Today's reality

HR needs to lead a change it hasn't practiced. Seventy-two percent of organizations make limited or no use of AI inside the HR function itself.



The focus area in action

HR goes first—designing, testing, and refining AI-enabled work where trust matters most. Ninety-four percent of Thinking Organizations ensure transparency for AI affecting employee careers, versus 62% of others.



The return

Thinking Organizations are almost 2x more likely to improve a broader range of business KPIs. They also deliver what employees say they need most to embrace AI: confidence that it can be trusted, cited by 43%.

The four prior focus areas ask the enterprise to transform how it works. This one asks HR to go first. This capability makes HR the proving ground for trusted AI, helping build the trust employees and leaders need to embrace AI at scale. The future workforce begins with the future HR function—and that is the potentially uncomfortable arithmetic of this change.

One capability in particular--trustworthy AI in people decisions—is critical for trust in AI throughout the organization. It enables the trust required for employees and leaders to embrace AI at scale.

Asked to lead a focus area it hasn't lived yet

HR is expected to guide the enterprise's workforce transformation—yet has limited experience applying AI within its own walls. The function charged with leading the change has barely started its own.

It isn't for lack of awareness. CHROs' top personal development priority—cited by 71% and more than any other leadership capability—is digital and AI fluency. But personal investment hasn't yet translated into adoption across the function.

"You can't lead what you don't understand."

Line De Decker
Chief People Officer, Haleon

Thinking Organizations, by the numbers:

81%

report moderate to high AI literacy across their HR teams.

94%

ensure transparency and explainability for AI systems that affect employee careers and well-being.

90%

report moderate to high AI governance and ethics capabilities, compared with 63% of others.

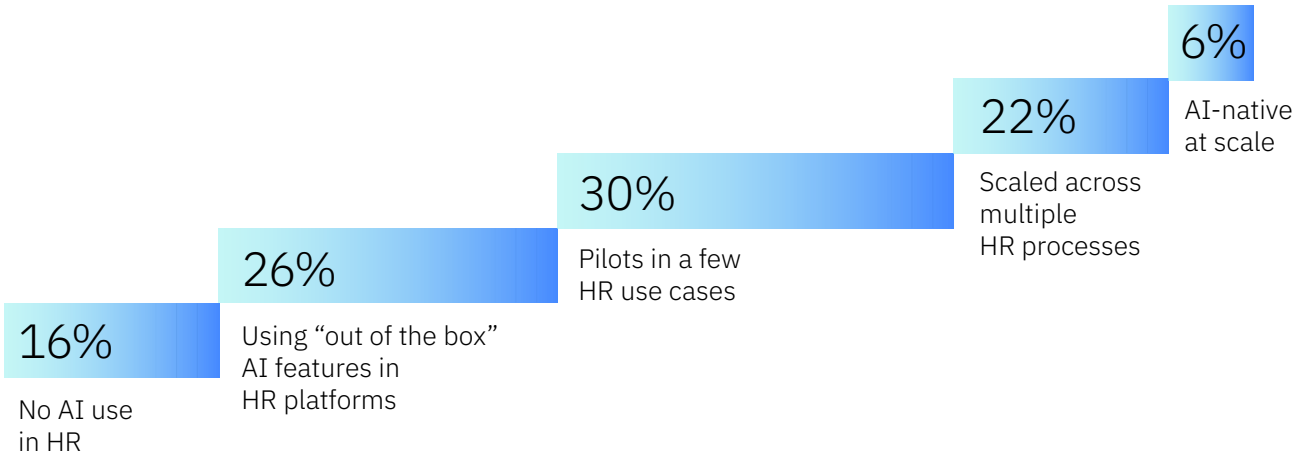
Prove it at home, then prescribe it

Leading CHROs are resolving this directly: making HR the first environment to design, test, and refine AI-enabled work. Anne-Catherine Ropers, Group Head of Human Resources, Crédit Agricole S.A., has embraced this focus: "I want to show that HR should be leading this. Not only sitting at the table, but leading this."

This proving ground serves a second purpose as well. By running its own redesign, HR shows the organization what converting freed hours into new capability actually looks like, in the one function every employee can see.

FIGURE 5

HR as change leader: Most are still at the starting line



HR's risk discipline is why it should go first. The function sits closest to the enterprise's highest-trust decisions: sensitive workforce data around hiring, promotion, pay, and performance. HR is also the first line of defense when people risks become enterprise risks. If AI cannot be made trustworthy in HR—where privacy, fairness, and employee confidence matter most—the rest of the enterprise will not trust it at scale. As Janine Vos, Managing Board Member and CHRO of Rabobank puts it: "I'm responsible for responsible AI."

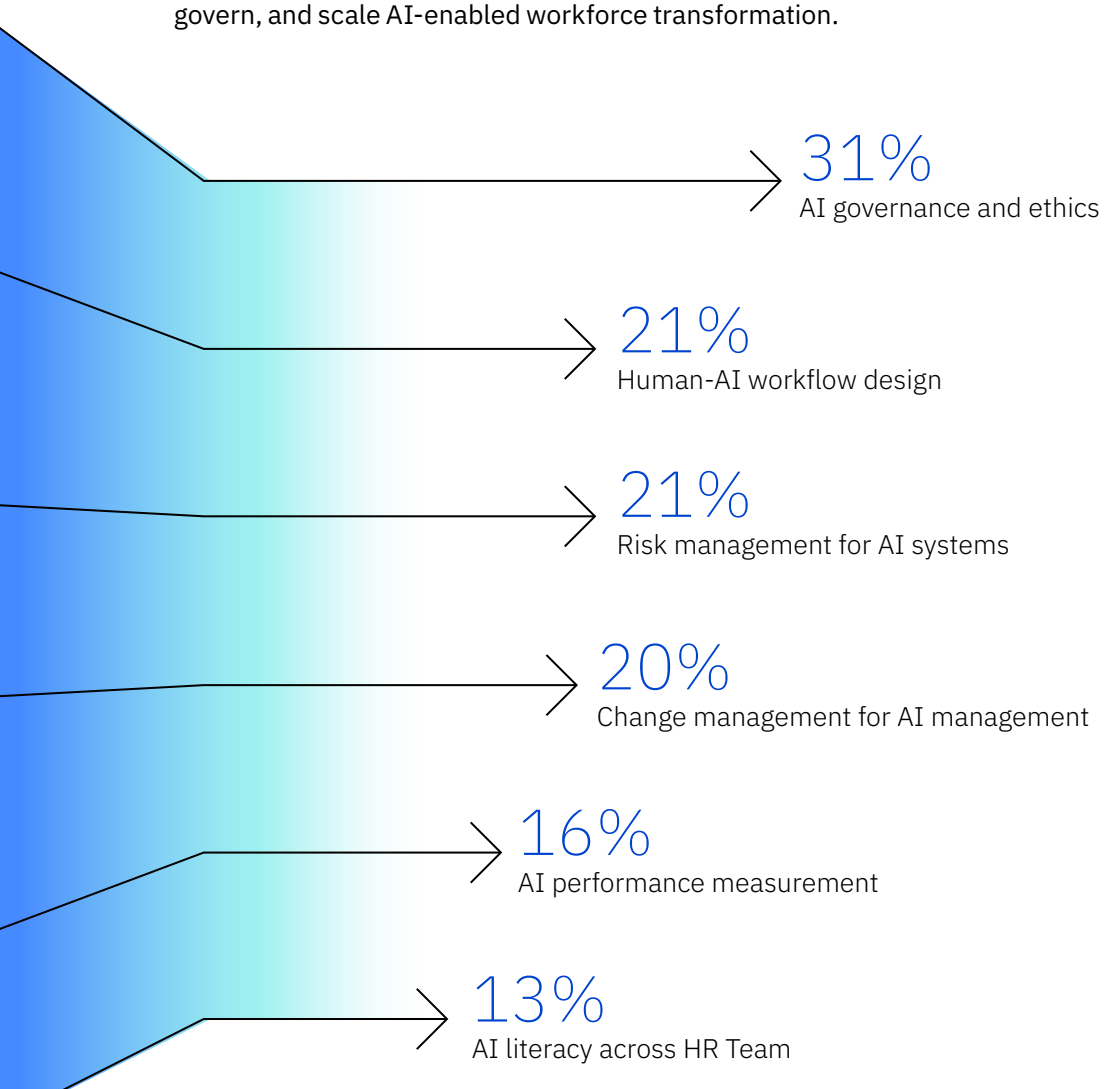
Business performance rises with HR AI maturity

The payoff reaches well past HR's walls. Organizations with mature HR AI capability—governance, architecture, measurement—are nearly two times more likely to positively impact a higher number of business KPIs. That multiplication of impact is what "growth capital" looks like on a dashboard, and it is how the proving ground feeds revenue and innovation. "What we're doing is aligning people capital to drive company performance," says Helen Cook, Chief People Officer of Finastra.

FIGURE 6

Few CHROs rate HR as highly capable for AI-enabled workforce transformation

Percent of executives rating HR as highly capable in each area required to design, govern, and scale AI-enabled workforce transformation.



From the CHRO's desk

Behind the decision

What I got wrong about AI

---

by Nickle LaMoreaux
Senior Vice President and CHRO, IBM

We built the tool. Nobody used it.
I've led HR at IBM long enough to watch AI go from buzzword to the operating system of how we work. Long enough to have made real mistakes—including one so controversial it tanked our employee NPS by 54 points.

And long enough to know that leaders asking "How do we transform our organizations with AI?" are asking the wrong question. The right one is: "How do we change the way people work?" AI is the easy part. Changing behaviors, mindsets, and ways of working is the hard part.

We thought we were experimenting with technology
In 2016, IBM had 350,000 employees in more than 170 countries, and we started where most organizations do: simple Q&A chatbots. It worked but the bots multiplied. Performance bots, career bots, benefits bots. The experience became fragmented and confusing.

So we consolidated everything into one platform: AskHR. Simple, clean, efficient.

And then nobody used it. Employees still emailed, still called, still walked down the hall to their HR partner.

Our instinct was to diagnose a technology problem. But the real problem was behavior. We had invested heavily in the tool and almost nothing in the change—no redesigned processes, no new incentives, no reckoning with the fact that people default to what they know. This is where most AI programs stall: not because the technology fails, but because the organization isn't prepared for the change.

The controversial decision
So we made a bold call. Overnight, we shut down the HR phone number and email globally. Our employee NPS dropped from +19 to -35.

But as employees used AskHR, the AI got smarter. As it got smarter, more complex questions got resolved—and our HR partners, freed from answering the same basic questions hundreds of times a week, could focus on work requiring human judgment. The lesson isn't to be extreme like IBM. It's that technology only delivers value when behavior, operating model, and culture change alongside it.

What surprised us
The resistance wasn't where I expected. Employees adapted fast; the harder cultural resistance came from my own team, whose identity was tied to having all the answers. Trust took time—employees didn't bring AskHR anything that felt important until it had earned that, gradually. And measuring the wrong thing proved as dangerous as not measuring at all. Usage counts were superficial; what mattered were containment rate, resolution quality, satisfaction, and cost per interaction.

Where we are today
AskHR now handles 16.3 million transactions a year. Ninety-five percent of questions are resolved without reaching a human. CSAT [Customer Satisfaction Score] has climbed to +55, and we've cut IBM's HR operating budget by 40% over four years. What I'm most proud of, though, is the HR team that emerged: more skilled, more engaged, better equipped to lead.

What I keep coming back to
AI transformation is not a technology initiative with a change management component. It's a behavior change initiative that technology enables.

I remain an AI optimist. If I could rename "artificial intelligence," I'd call it "augmented intelligence"—technology that elevates human work rather than replacing it. The future isn't already written. The technology matters, but how we apply it matters more. And that future can be very bright.

*Abridged excerpt from IBM CHRO LinkedIn blog. For full text, visit: https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/behind-decision-what-i-got-wrong-ai-nickle-lamoreaux-sadyc/

CHRO priorities for a Thinking Organization

Set the enterprise rules for how AI can be used in people decisions.

Define the minimum standards for transparency, human review, escalation, and documentation when AI influences hiring, promotion, pay, performance, or separation decisions. Writing those standards takes AI literacy. Build enough AI fluency across the HR leadership team to know what the systems actually do before ruling on how they may be used. HR should establish the operating standard here before the rest of the enterprise scales AI into higher-risk decisions.

Reallocate HR capacity toward the work only people can do.

As AI takes on more administrative and analytical tasks, deliberately shift HR time into manager coaching, workforce judgment, sensitive employee decisions, and organizational interventions. The point is not just efficiency; it is to use AI to increase the amount of higher-value human work HR can do.

Measure how AI-freed capacity in HR gets reinvested—and tie it to business outcomes.

Track where AI takes routine work off HR's plate, then deliberately redirect those hours into manager coaching, early intervention, workforce mobility, or strategic planning. Only 42% of organizations are reinvesting AI-freed capacity in skilling and innovation. HR should model what the other 58% are missing. That reinvestment becomes your proof point for the enterprise.

"Offering an organization a design framework for transformation is HR work. It's actually the HR work everyone aspires to."

geneviève bich
Vice President - Human Resources (CHRO), METRO, and Board member

"The HR function of the future will not become less human because it uses AI. It will become more human."

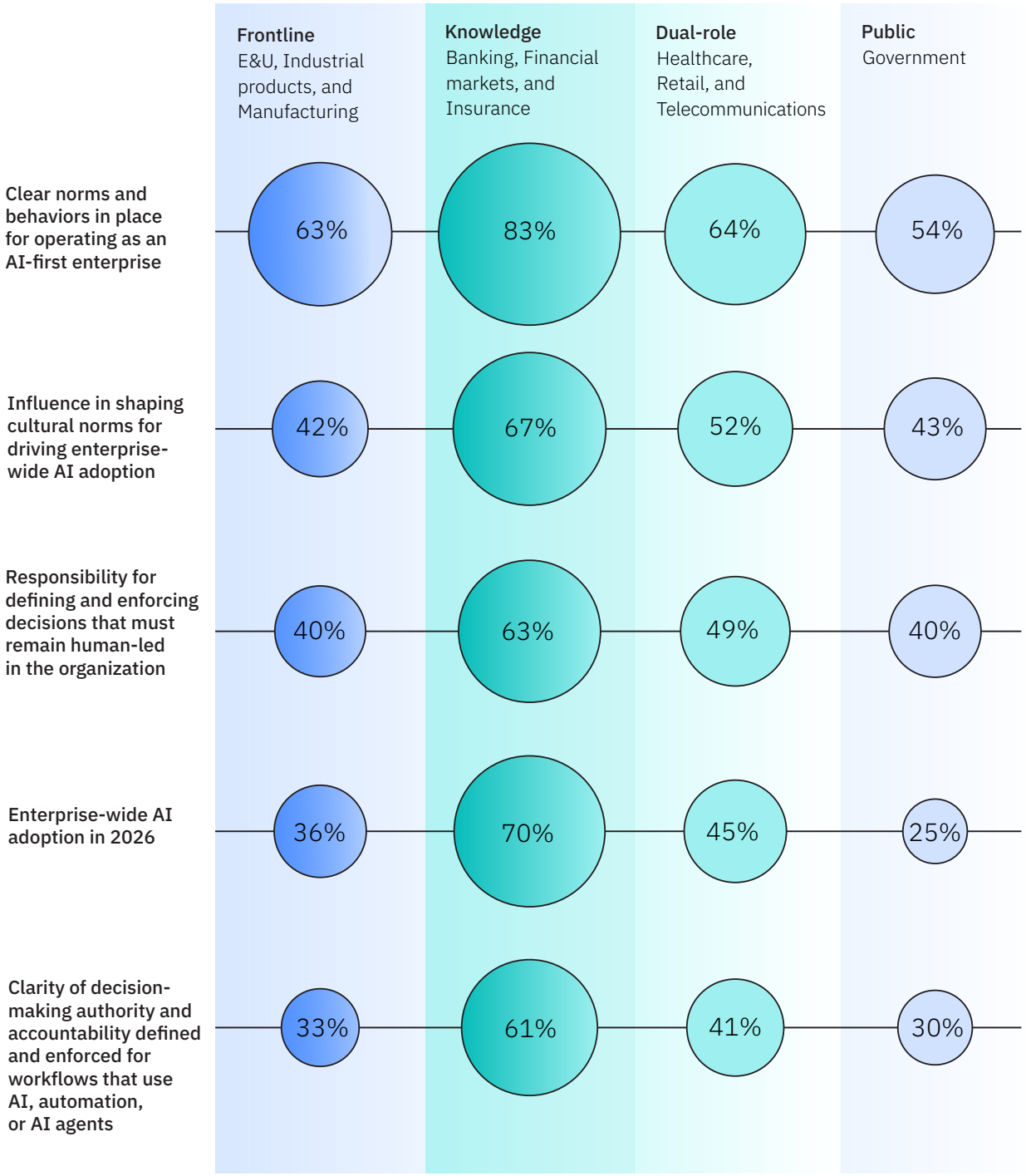
Jaime Jordana, Chief People Officer, Codere

FIGURE 7

CHRO perspectives, by industry type

The Thinking Organization is not confined to any single industry. Yet organizations in different sectors are approaching AI adoption, accountability, culture, and the CHRO's role from different starting points. Looking across major industry groups reveals meaningful variation in how these management choices are taking shape.

Percentage of CHROs by industry type who report each characteristic



> "We need to make sure the mechanisms for people to feel safe are maintained."
>
> **Lynn McManus,** Chief People Officer, Nationwide Building Society

Thinking by design

The five focus areas in this report share one feature: none requires new technology. The AI is already installed. What separates Thinking Organizations from others are the management decisions CHROs make. What remains inherently human, and who decides? Are the work and the workforce redesigned together or one at a time? Are AI's gains banked or reinvested in the people and experience that drive performance? Are human skills left to erode or deliberately rebuilt? And, does HR prove the change within itself before asking the enterprise to make it?

Those decisions are being made now, in this year's budget cycles and deployment schedules. In nearly half of organizations, they are being made before HR enters the room. As AI absorbs more of the routine work, the questions that remain are the human ones, and they will land on whoever is prepared to answer them. But CHROs have a critical role in building the Thinking Organization of the future. It starts now, with these five focus areas.

Focus area	Thinking Organization capabilities	Actions to take
CHROs own what is inherently human, even in an AI world.	Human + AI work accountability	☐ Build business and tech fluency. ☐ Design and govern decision rights and accountability. ☐ Negotiate shared accountability with C-suite peers.
CHROs redesign work—and the workforce it demands.	Judgment in workflow processes Work redesign Workforce recomposition	☐ Make the decision layer explicit in AI-enabled work. ☐ Make work redesign a standing business discipline. ☐ Translate the new work design into workforce planning.
CHROs advance skill growth and prevent skill erosion.	Entry-leveland career development strategy Reskilling	☐ Use AI to shorten the path from current skills to future. ☐ Manage skill erosion as a talent risk. ☐ Preserve critical early-career learning pathways.
CHROs shape the experience and culture that fuel growth.	Gains reinvestment Psychological safety Performance and growth management	☐ Normalize constructive challenge. ☐ Rewrite performance goals for human + AI contribution. ☐ Shape how AI-created capacity supports workforce priorities and employee experience.
CHROs build trust in AI by making HR the proving ground.	Trustworthy AI in people decisions	☐ Set enterprise rules for how to use AI in people decisions. ☐ Reallocate HR capacity toward work only people can do. ☐ Measure how AI-freed capacity in HR gets reinvested—and tie it to business outcomes.

Research methodology

To understand how Chief Human Resource Officers can turn AI from a productivity tool into a source of growth, the IBM Institute for Business Value, in collaboration with Oxford Economics, conducted two complementary global surveys from April to June 2026. The first gathered insights from 1,500 CHROs and senior executives responsible for workforce strategy on how they are designing work, culture, and the workforce for an AI-enabled enterprise. The second engaged 8,800 full-time employees worldwide to capture their experience with AI at work, with every employee respondent screened for at least a basic awareness of AI.

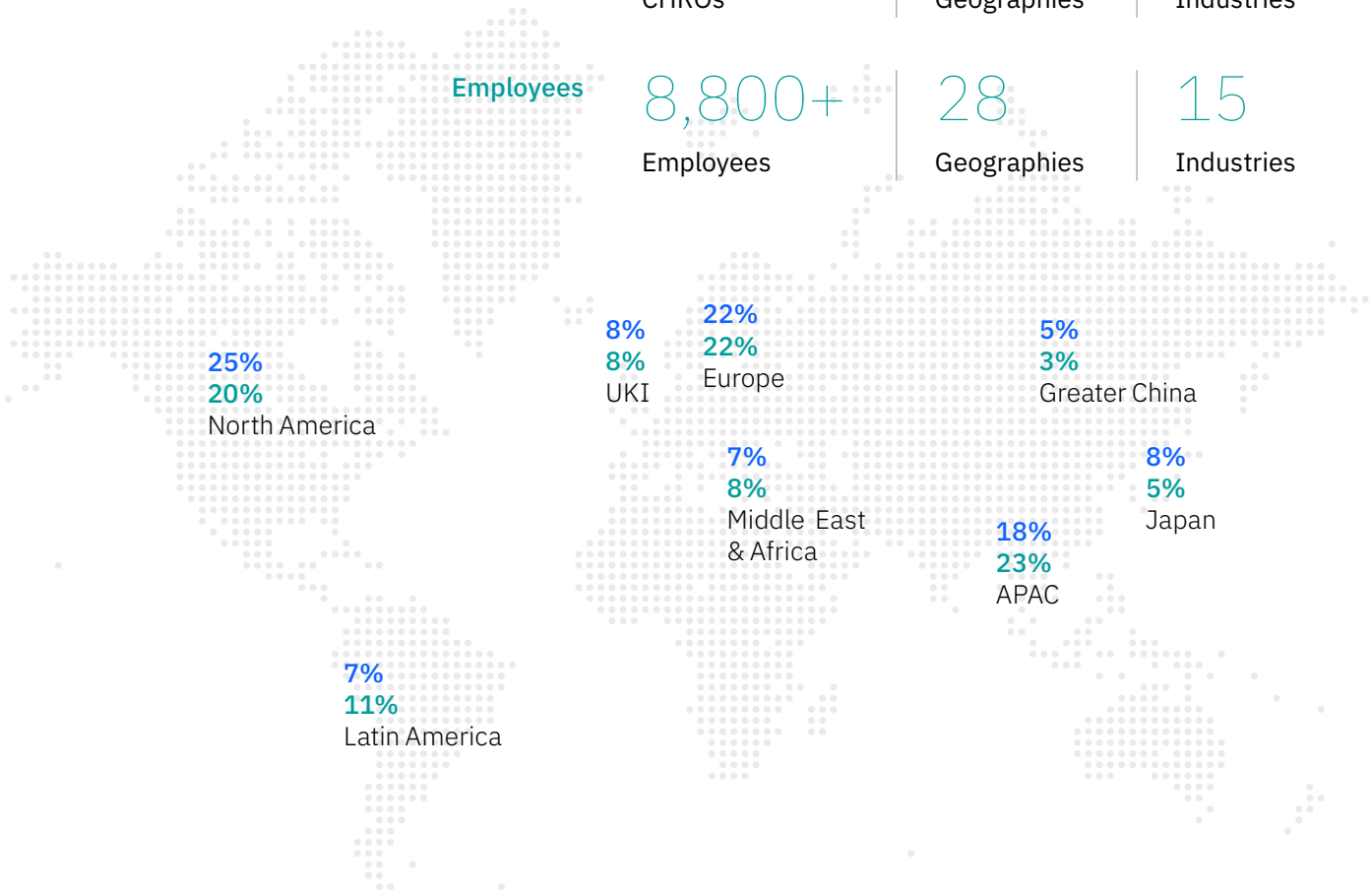
Respondents to the executive survey included decision-makers with direct responsibility for HR, people, talent, and workforce strategy. Participants represented 23 industries and 21 geographies, spanning organizations of varying sizes and sectors, from US$250 million to US$123.7 billion in annual revenue or budget and from 200 to more than 880,000 employees. The employee survey spanned 28 countries. This diverse composition ensures the findings capture a wide range of AI maturity levels, strategic priorities, and regional contexts across the global business landscape.

Executives

1,500	21	23
CHROs	Geographies	Industries

Employees

8,800+	28	15
Employees	Geographies	Industries



In addition to descriptive analysis of expectations, priorities, and trends from the basic frequency data, we designed and implemented an analytical framework to better understand the relationships between how organizations approach AI and the outcomes they achieve. The executive survey provides the organizational view of capability, design, and outcomes, while the employee survey captures the workforce experience. Unless otherwise noted, relationships reflect observed associations in cross-sectional data and should not be interpreted as proof of direct causality.

Analytical framework

To identify what separates the organizations converting AI into growth from those converting it into savings, and to group organizations by strategic maturity, we applied four complementary analytical techniques: a capability index, a mandate-by-integration segmentation, a judgment protection typology, and a culture readiness index.

Thinking organization capability index

The capability index was designed to measure how closely an organization exhibits the characteristics of a Thinking Organization, and how those capabilities translate into measurable value from human and AI work. The index is built from 10 survey questions selected across the five focus areas of the Thinking Organization framework. Questions were first mapped to the focus area they best represented conceptually, then screened within each shift to identify those showing the strongest relationship to the reported percentage of value generated from human and AI work.

The 10 items included: CHRO strategic standing in AI; work redesigned for human and AI collaboration; roles emphasizing human judgment; workforce recomposition capability; ability to challenge AI outputs; reinvestment of productivity gains into people; AI governance mechanisms; reskilling roadmap; entry-level hiring strategy; and trust and ethics not constraining AI deployment.

These 10 items were selected because they conceptually comprise the value components that influence and operationalize the perceived value of human and AI work. To ensure comparability, all responses were standardized onto a common scale and combined to define the five underlying themes. The five theme scores were restandardized and combined with equal weighting, so that each strategic theme contributed equally to the overall index regardless of how many survey questions sat beneath it. Organizations were then ranked on their overall capability index score and divided into performance quartiles, with the top quartile classified as Thinking Organizations, comprising 375 organizations. This approach grounds the index conceptually in the five strategic themes while anchoring it empirically to the outcomes explored, creating a balanced measure that can benchmark organizations and evaluate differences in AI-enabled value creation.

We also tested the index against control variables, including industry, geography, organization size, and AI adoption maturity. The degree of AI adoption emerged as a significant predictor of the capability score, while industry, geography, and organizational size did not.

Judgment protection typology

Human judgment is one of the five components behind the capability index, so we next examined how deeply organizations have structurally protected that judgment. To assess whether organizations have built the human judgment layers needed to scale AI responsibly, we used a rule-based classification that tests whether judgment is prioritized, authorized, and embedded. We treated each layer as a yes or no signal:

1. **Priority:** judgment skills prioritized for AI-enabled roles, counted as present where at least three of four signals held: judgment under uncertainty and ambiguity; supervising, validating, or overriding AI outputs; ethical reasoning and responsible AI use; and exception handling and escalation.
2. **Authority:** formal authority for human judgment, counted as present where at least two of three signals held: authority to intervene in AI-enabled work; responsibility for defining and enforcing which decisions must remain human-led; and defined decision rights and escalation paths for AI.
3. **Embedding:** judgment built into how work is designed rather than left to individual initiative, counted as present where at least two of three signals held: roles redesigned to emphasize judgment, exception handling, and oversight; workflow outcomes actively tracked, with authority to escalate, pause, or override AI-enabled decisions; and roles redesigned to prepare the workforce around human judgment.

Across the 757 organizations with valid data on all three layers, we sorted organizations into four states and compared them on the change in employee confidence in AI-enabled decisions over the prior 12 months. The states were judgment protected, where all three layers were present (10%); judgment ornamental, where judgment was prioritized but authority or embedding was incomplete (11%); judgment improvised, where some authority or embedding existed but judgment was not strongly prioritized (56%); and judgment absent, where no strong protection layer was present (22%).

Culture readiness index

Judgment protection captures the formal layers that authorize and embed human oversight; culture shapes whether employees feel safe to exercise that oversight day to day. To test whether organizational culture separates stronger AI performers from weaker ones, we built an index by averaging six items measured on a common four-point agreement scale: trust and ethics not limiting AI, psychological safety to question or override AI, an active employee feedback loop, clear behavioral norms, transparency and explainability, and manager readiness to lead alongside AI. We sorted organizations into three groups of roughly equal size, low, moderate, and high readiness (low, n=459; moderate, n=452; high, n=589), and compared them on AI performance outcomes and on the change in employee confidence in AI-enabled decisions.

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IBM has been providing expertise to help organizations win in the marketplace for more than a century. Clients can realize the potential of AI and better navigate a changing world using IBM's deep industry, functional, and technical expertise; enterprise-grade technology solutions; and science-based research innovations.

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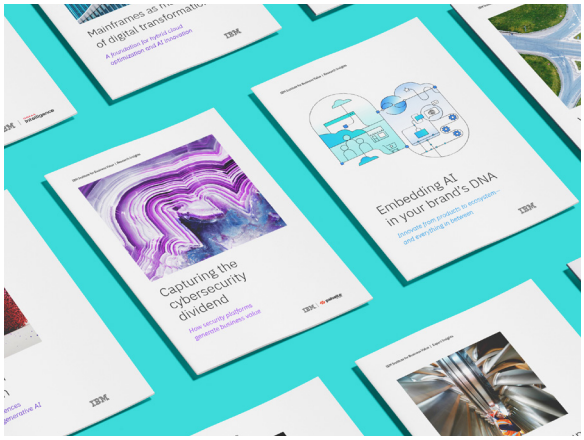
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